



FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 13

IOWA

WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside Iowa's family courts and child-welfare system.

42

IOWA FAMILIES ON RECORD · 41
CHILDREN IMPACTED · 20 MONTHS
MEDIAN MONTHS LOST OF PARENTING
TIME

REPORT GENERATED
APRIL 27, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED
21 OF 99

COMPILED BY
MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

IOWA AT A GLANCE.

Across 42 Iowa families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED 41 42 of 42 families reported child counts	MEDIAN ATTORNEY FEES \$3,000 per reporting family	MEDIAN MONTHS LOST 20 of parenting time	WENT PRO SE 61.9% 40.5% after running out of money
SUBMISSIONS 42	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY 1.0	FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN 42 of 42	COUNTIES REPRESENTED 21

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so Iowa families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

02 THE COST OF IOWA FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

EXPENSE CATEGORY	RESPONSES	MEDIAN	MEAN	TOTAL REPORTED
Attorney Fees	27	\$3,000	\$25,811	\$696,901
Lost Wages	25	\$20,000	\$152,880	\$3,822,000
Other Court Fees	17	\$0	\$10,824	\$184,000
Therapy / Evaluations	20	\$1,750	\$7,485	\$149,700
Reunification Services	15	\$0	\$800	\$12,000
GAL Fees	16	\$0	\$2,344	\$37,500
Asset Loss ¹	26	\$60,000	—	—
Estimated Median Family Impact	—	\$84,750	—	—

Median vs. mean: Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers.

1. On asset loss: One respondent reported an extreme outlier that skews the mean beyond usefulness. We report the median (\$60,000) and suppress the mean and total, pending data-quality review. Lost Wages also contains wide variance; median is the honest headline.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS

Median months lost		20	1.7 yrs
Mean months lost		31	2.6 yrs
Total across all families		659	54.9 yrs

03 WHO IS REPORTING · IOWA

Most families documenting in Iowa are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Active case: stuck or delayed		16	38%
Not provided		10	24%
Case closed: more than 2 years ago		10	24%
Case closed: within last 2 years		6	14%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Both Family Court and CPS		23	55%
CPS (Child Protective Services) Only		7	17%
Family Court Only		6	14%
Unknown		6	14%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

1 – 3 years		15	36%
6 months – 1 year		8	19%
5 – 10 years		5	12%
3 – 5 years		3	7%
Over 10 years		2	5%

CUSTODY STATUS

No Contact / Total Loss of Access		16	38%
Visitation Only		9	21%
Adopted Out (Rights Terminated)		7	17%
Children in Foster Care		4	10%
Full Custody		3	7%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Polk		4	10%
Woodbury		3	7%
Marshall		3	7%
Benton		2	5%
Dallas		2	5%
Floyd		1	2%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

False Accusations CPS (Non-Medical) (Vengeful ex-partner, malicious report)		9	21%
Other: (Short answer)		8	19%
Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)		7	17%
Environmental/Poverty-Related (Lack of housing, utilities, etc.)		4	10%
Child Protective Services (CPS / DCF)		3	7%

05 PARENT VOICES — IOWA

Quotes appear as submitted. Long submissions are trimmed with [...] to fit the page; the full unedited quote is available in the online version of this report.



Punished an innocent, safe parent and ripped my children away unnecessarily. They destroyed my family and career.

— HEATHER

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

Iowa CPS wrongfully founded me of child abuse despite a lack of credible evidence, failed to preserve or produce proof of my timely appeal submission, and has continued to uphold that finding through a procedurally flawed process. Their actions have directly contributed to [...]

— IOWA PARENT · LINDSAY

MORE VOICES FROM IOWA

Family Court has destroyed my children and I. Time and money will never replace what the enemy has stolen from us.

— PATRICIA

Destroyed our family unit, abuse and cruelty to the children, and all of the cousins and siblings involved. Severe trauma, IT HAS BEEN THE WORST EXPERIENCE IN OUR LIVES! This is a very difficult case, I have more details and information.

— MELISSA

Lost my son to a corrupt DHS/CPS System

— KODY

They have tore our family apart lied on us manipulated us ripped grandkids away from loving grandparents

— CASSIE

Emotionally abused my children by distorting the facts of the case and withholding visitation

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This system has ripped our family apart. We are grandparents raising three grandchildren, and they took the girls for alleged alleged sexual assault. there is not that much evidence and supposedly this happened years ago and I just want a girls to come home but they won't even [...]

— RENEE

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Destroyed it. Destroyed our mental health, our stability, our trust in the system

— AMBER

The system has failed us and ripped us limb from limb

— JEANANE

Total devastation. Irreversible trauma and emotional damage

— ERICA

The family court process enabled my abuser to present as the victim while extensive, documented evidence of domestic violence, coercive control, community defamation, and severe trauma to me and my children went unaddressed. The result has been psychological disability, loss of [...]

— EMILLY

Has made me question myself as a parent, and I have now developed severe depression and anxiety.

— GENESIS

They moved up my court date. They tried to make me quick claim my house

— COURTNEY

They didn't just take my children—they fractured our sense of safety, turned our home into a case file, and left a family grieving each other while still alive.

— DESTINY

It was hell that still has never end. Not amount of time can be given back and it has traumatized me and my children and had an effect on my youngest child's custody. Not being allowed to see my youngest child. And not being allowed to seek safety from my ex to give guardianship [...]

— LOIS

As tore us apart all they wanna do is bridge orders for my kids playing games with me not ratification at all it's a game to them

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



I went from being the primary, daily presence in my children's lives to being reduced to visitation through a process that was opaque, procedurally unfair, and impossible to challenge. Now I have court-ordered parenting time that is intentionally withheld for months at a time [...]

— NATE

DHS refused to encourage reunification. Put my daughter in teachers home instead of family. My daughter has been manipulated against me. I can't concentrate at work, depression, PTSD, anxiety. This has destroyed our family!!

— MICHELLE

It has emotionally drained our family and our daughter who begs to come home every visit we get with her..

— EMILY AND IAN

Family fraud court has annihilated my family, my financial security, my physical, mental and even my dental health. Family court has triggered my C-PTSD so badly that I am unable to work, unable to trust others, unable to be happy, unable to relate to anyone that is not mourning [...]

— JODI

The courts today care more about protecting workers right, than that of parents. Children are not just a bonus check there our future, why would we want to ruin there childhood with lies and coaching.

— PAULA

My oldest daughter has now been hospitalized in a psych ward due to her step mom as of january this year I had hearing in feb and proved abuse in the home but the courts said they did no wrong my youngest child stated this last week she wanted to kill herself at her dad's cause [...]

— AMBER

It has ruined my life

— HEATHER

Left out an older child by friends of the court and let exes mom get guardianship where ex lived... because money matters more than saftey when everyone in the circle knows eachothers secrets"

— AMBER

25 Iowa parents submitted ranked quotes. 25 appear in this report; the remainder are available at standwithmeg.com/ia.

06 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this Iowa report comes from Iowa respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in Iowa — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 42 Iowa families reporting here are not the universe of Iowa families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – April 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte–Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 5 independent families name the same actor.

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ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

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